original females gave birth after being captured and had to be replaced; another died. But the final tally is a healthy one: three males, five females.

How this cheetah octet evolves its social patterns will be crucial. Cheetahs typically live in three formations—lone females with cubs, groups of sibling males known as 'coalitions', and the rare lone ranger. Although female cheetahs are promiscuous, the last thing anyone would want is two expensive imports facing off in mortal combat in the wild. There's a lot riding on this project. An outlay of Rs 91.65 crore, for one. So everyone is hoping all the fragile socialising between prey, cousins from the fiercer felid families, sundry other rivals and intra-cheetah groups works out reasonably well. The next phase would then involve trying to build up a stable source population at Kuno that would eventually feed other reserves such as Mukundra, Shergarh and Bhainsrorgarh in Rajasthan and Madhav National Park and Gandhi Sagar Sanctuary in MP.

The other question relates to the larger ecological one. Does this have value beyond being a majestic showpiece item, almost akin to a latter-day version of the zoo, updated with environmentally correct sounds? (Zoos, incidentally, are an unacknowledged artefact of wildlife destruction, having decimated cheetahs throughout the previous century.) Project Tiger is an example to go by. Famously, because of being at the apex of the food chain, the robustness of tiger populations also meant the preservation of entire ecosystems of unquantifiable preciousness. Minister Yadav proffers a similar argument here. "Project Cheetah aims to bring back the only large mammal to go extinct in independent India. The project is not just about the charismatic cheetah itself, but more about its role in being able to restore the balance within ecosystems it inhabited. While the tiger has served as the flagship species for forest systems, the cheetah will fill this void for open forests, grasslands and savannahs," he says. With careful management, it could restore neglected habitats, conserve biodiversity and harness its ability to sequester carbon to the maximum potential. And promoting ecotourism on the side will do no harm to community livelihoods for local folk like Dinesh—the Sahariyas, for instance, listed as "expert woodsmen" with a variety of forest-related skills, are also dirt-poor, with high malnutrition levels and only a few able to rely on farming in an irrigation-scarce area.

WHY KUNO?

In 2009, when work on cheetah reintroduction began in right earnest, the Kuno Palpur Sanctuary (as it was called then) had already qualified as a viable habitat for translocating Asiatic lions from Gir. Once the cheetah plan began taking shape, the Dehradun-based Wildlife Institute of India (WII) conducted a feasibility study at Kuno and Nauradehi in MP and Shahgarh in Rajasthan and found them appropriate. When the project was revived in January 2020, the WII conducted a reassessment at 10 sites across India, and found Kuno most suitable. The factors that went in its favour? One, the initial groundwork for the coming of the lions, such as the relocation of 24 villages, which made the reserve free of human habitation. Two, an adequate prey base. Three, it offers a forest-grassland mosaic as part of the Khathiar Gir dry deciduous ecoregion, with major tree species like the salai, kardhai, khair and tendu speckled with savannah. Four, climate. Cheetahs thrive best in temperature zones of 23-40°C, and Kuno fit the bill, especially for its arid/ semi-arid properties—higher baseline humidity can affect the success of a project such as this. First notified as a sanctuary in 1981 with 344 sq. km, Kuno was upgraded to a national park in 2018 with the addition of 413 sq. km. Unsurprisingly, these were the most sought-after hunting preserves of the Scindia rulers of Gwalior—back in the day when tigers abounded, as also exceptionally large heads of chital.

The sceptics are not convinced—and their arguments revolve precisely around the suitability of prey base and habitat. Wildlife conservationist Valmik Thapar, whose book *Exotic Aliens* famously describes lions and cheetahs as historically non-native to the subcontinent, derives the reasons for his vociferous veto right there. The large open grasslands vital for the cheetah are simply non-existent in India, he says—at best, they can inhabit fenced areas, possibly being fed by hand or baiting in his opinion. "After seeing 400 different cheetahs in Africa, and studying every nuance of the animal, I

IN COLD BLOOD

AND THEN THERE WERE NONE...

A few months after India's Independence, Ramanuj Pratap Singh Deo, the ruler of Koriya (a princely state that was under the Eastern States Agency and is now part of modern-day Chhattisgarh), saw three cheetahs while driving at night. They were all sitting huddled together, perhaps blinded and scared by the lights.

As per an account of the hunt, sent by the ruler's secretary to a popular taxidermist, Van Ingen, "The first bullet killed one and the second, the remaining two. The second bullet, after having gone through one, struck the other, which was behind it, and killed it." The cheetahs were almost identical—all males—and were believed to be from the same litter. It wasn't known whether the animals were born in Koriya or had migrated from elsewhere.

In his 1923 book, *Wild Animals in Central India*, conservationist Dunbar Brander stated that the cheetah had almost disappeared from